GLOUCESTER
ZAKAT FUND
CHARITY FOR LOCAL RESIDENTS

COMPLAINTS POLICY

Document Information	
Policy Name	Complaints Policy
Version	1.0
Policy Owner	Board of Trustees
Complaints Lead	Chair of Trustees
Approved by	Board of Trustees
Date Approved	01/02/2026
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Related Policies	Safeguarding Policy, Whistleblowing Policy, Equality Diversity and Inclusion Policy, Data Protection Policy

1. Introduction and Purpose

1.1 Introduction

Gloucester Zakat Charity ("the Charity") is committed to providing high-quality services and support to our beneficiaries, donors, volunteers, partners, and the wider community. We strive to meet the expectations of everyone we work with, but we recognise that there may be occasions when things go wrong or when people feel their concerns have not been adequately addressed.

We welcome feedback, including complaints, as an opportunity to learn, improve our services, and put things right. This policy sets out how we will handle complaints fairly, consistently, and in a timely manner.

1.2 Purpose

The purpose of this Complaints Policy is to:

- Provide a clear and accessible process for anyone to raise concerns or make a complaint
- Ensure all complaints are handled fairly, promptly, and impartially
- Explain how complaints will be investigated and responded to
- Set out realistic timeframes for each stage of the process
- Describe how complainants can appeal if they are dissatisfied with the outcome
- Enable the Charity to learn from complaints and improve its services
- Demonstrate our commitment to accountability and transparency

1.3 Our Commitment

We are committed to:

- Treating all complainants with courtesy and respect
- Taking every complaint seriously, regardless of how it is received
- Investigating complaints thoroughly and impartially
- Responding honestly, even when we have made mistakes
- Apologising and putting things right where appropriate
- Learning from complaints to improve our services
- Protecting complainants from any form of victimisation

2. Scope

2.1 What is a Complaint?

For the purposes of this policy, a complaint is defined as any expression of dissatisfaction about any aspect of the Charity's work, services, decisions, or the conduct of any person associated with the Charity, which requires a response.

2.2 Who Can Complain?

This policy applies to complaints from:

- Beneficiaries who have received (or applied to receive) support from the Charity
- Donors and supporters
- Volunteers
- Members of the public
- Partner organisations

- Professionals or agencies who interact with the Charity
- Anyone else affected by the Charity's work

2.3 What Can Be Complained About?

Complaints may relate to:

- Decisions about grant applications (although this does not create a right to a grant)
- The quality or timeliness of services provided
- The conduct or behaviour of trustees or volunteers
- Communication or lack of communication
- Breach of confidentiality or data protection
- Discrimination or unfair treatment
- Failure to follow our policies or procedures
- The administration or management of the Charity
- Fundraising activities
- Any other matter relating to the Charity's operations

2.4 What is Not Covered by This Policy?

This policy does not cover:

- General enquiries or requests for information
- Initial requests for service or support (these should follow normal application processes)
- Matters that are subject to legal proceedings
- Complaints about organisations other than Gloucester Zakat Charity
- Anonymous malicious allegations (see Section 11)
- Complaints made more than 12 months after the event (unless there are exceptional circumstances)

Certain types of concerns have separate reporting processes:

Type of Concern	Relevant Policy/Process
Safeguarding concerns (children or adults at risk)	Safeguarding Policy
Suspected fraud, financial crime, or serious wrongdoing	Whistleblowing Policy
Data protection breaches or subject access requests	Data Protection Policy

3. How to Make a Complaint

3.1 Contact Details

Complaints can be made in the following ways:

By email: complaints@gloucesterzakat.org.uk (or the Charity's general email address)

By post: Complaints, Gloucester Zakat Charity, 64 Salisbury Road, Gloucester, GL1 4JQ

In person: To any trustee at a meeting, event, or by prior arrangement

By telephone: Via the Charity's contact number (if available on website)

Correspondence marked 'Private and Confidential' will be treated as such.

3.2 Support in Making a Complaint

We want to ensure that everyone can access our complaints process. We can provide:

- Assistance in writing a complaint for those who need help
- Translation or interpretation services where reasonably practicable
- Alternative formats (large print, easy read) on request
- A named person to support the complainant through the process if needed

Please let us know if you need any support or adjustments.

4. The Complaints Process

We operate a two-stage complaints process, plus an appeal stage if needed:

Stage	Description	Timeframe
Stage 1: Informal Resolution	Concern raised with a trustee and addressed promptly	Within 7 working days
Stage 2: Formal Complaint	Written complaint investigated by a trustee	Response within 14 working days
Stage 3: Appeal	Review by Chair (or another trustee if Chair involved)	Decision within 28 days

5. Stage 1: Informal Resolution

We encourage anyone with a concern to raise it informally in the first instance, as this often allows issues to be resolved quickly and to everyone's satisfaction.

5.1 How to Raise an Informal Concern

If you have a concern, you should:

- Speak directly to a trustee as soon as possible after the issue arises
- Explain what happened and what you would like to be done about it
- Allow the trustee an opportunity to investigate and respond

5.2 How We Will Respond

The trustee will:

- Listen to your concern and ask questions to understand the situation
- Take any immediate action necessary
- Investigate the matter if needed
- Try to resolve the concern to your satisfaction within 7 working days
- Explain what has been done and why

5.3 Recording Informal Complaints

Even if a concern is resolved informally, we will make a brief record including:

- The nature of the concern
- The date it was raised
- How it was resolved
- Any learning points identified

This helps us identify patterns and improve our services.

5.4 When Informal Resolution is Not Appropriate

Some concerns are too serious to be dealt with informally and should proceed directly to Stage 2. These include:

- Allegations of serious misconduct by a trustee or volunteer
- Matters that may involve safeguarding concerns
- Allegations of fraud or financial impropriety
- Complaints involving potential legal liability
- Situations where informal resolution has already been attempted without success

6. Stage 2: Formal Complaint

If you are not satisfied with the outcome of Stage 1, or if the matter is too serious for informal resolution, you can make a formal complaint.

6.1 Making a Formal Complaint

To make a formal complaint, please write to us (by email or letter) including:

- Your full name and contact details (address, telephone, email)
- If you prefer not to be contacted in a particular way, please let us know
- A clear description of what happened, including dates, times, locations, and people involved
- What you feel was unsatisfactory
- What outcome you are hoping for
- Any supporting evidence or documents

Please make your complaint as soon as possible after the event. Complaints made more than 12 months after the event may not be investigated unless there are exceptional circumstances.

6.2 Acknowledgement

We will:

- Acknowledge your complaint within 7 working days of receipt
- Confirm who will be investigating the complaint
- Provide a copy of this policy if not already provided
- Contact you if we need any clarification or further information

6.3 Investigation

The investigating trustee will:

- Review all relevant information and evidence
- Speak to relevant people as necessary
- Consider the complaint impartially and objectively
- Seek specialist advice if needed
- Keep the complainant informed of progress

6.4 Response

We will send a written response within 14 working days of acknowledgement. If this is not possible due to the complexity of the complaint, we will send a holding reply explaining the delay and when we expect to respond.

The response will include:

- A summary of the complaint
- Our findings and conclusions
- Any action we have taken or will take
- An apology if we have made a mistake
- Information about how to appeal if you are not satisfied

Note: Due to data protection requirements, we may not be able to disclose details about actions taken in relation to other individuals.

7. Stage 3: Appeal

7.1 When to Appeal

If you are not satisfied with the response to your formal complaint, you may appeal the decision. Appeals must be submitted within 28 days of receiving our response.

7.2 How to Appeal

To appeal, please write to the Chair of Trustees (or, if the Chair was involved in the original complaint or investigation, to another trustee) explaining:

- Why you are dissatisfied with the response
- What specific aspects of the decision you believe were wrong
- Any new information or evidence that was not previously considered
- What outcome you are seeking

7.3 Appeal Review

The appeal will be reviewed by a trustee who was not involved in the original complaint or investigation. The reviewer will consider:

- Whether the complaint was properly investigated
- Whether the response was reasonable based on the evidence
- Whether this policy was followed correctly
- Any new information provided

7.4 Appeal Decision

A decision on the appeal will be communicated within 28 days. The appeal decision will be final and will explain:

- Whether the appeal is upheld, partially upheld, or not upheld
- The reasons for the decision
- Any further action that will be taken

There is no further internal appeal beyond this stage.

8. Escalation to External Bodies

If you remain dissatisfied after completing our internal complaints process, you may be able to raise your concerns with external bodies:

Charity Commission: If you believe there has been misconduct or mismanagement at the Charity, you can report concerns to the Charity Commission (www.gov.uk/complain-about-charity).

Fundraising Regulator: For complaints about fundraising practices (www.fundraisingregulator.org.uk).

Information Commissioner's Office: For complaints about data protection (www.ico.org.uk).

Police: For allegations of criminal activity.

9. Urgent and Serious Matters

9.1 Emergencies

If your concern involves immediate risk to someone's safety, please take immediate action:

- Call the emergency services (999) if someone is in immediate danger
- Contact the local authority safeguarding team if a child or vulnerable adult is at risk
- Then notify the Charity as soon as possible

9.2 Safeguarding Concerns

Complaints that involve potential safeguarding concerns will be handled under the Safeguarding Policy. The safety and welfare of children and adults at risk takes priority over the complaints process.

9.3 Potential Compensation Claims

If a complaint involves allegations that may result in a claim for compensation (such as damage or loss of property, personal injury, or financial loss):

- The complainant will be informed that their complaint is being escalated
- The Board of Trustees will be notified immediately
- The Board will assess whether the complaint constitutes a potential insurance claim
- If relevant insurance is held, insurers will be notified within the required timeframe
- No admission of liability will be made without trustee approval and, where applicable, consultation with insurers
- All correspondence and evidence will be retained securely

10. Complaints About Trustees

Complaints about the conduct of an individual trustee will be handled carefully to ensure fairness to all parties:

- The trustee who is the subject of the complaint will not be involved in investigating or deciding the outcome
- The complaint will be investigated by other trustees, or by an independent person if appropriate
- The trustee complained about will be given an opportunity to respond to the allegations
- If the complaint is about the Chair, another trustee will handle the investigation
- Serious complaints about trustees may need to be reported to the Charity Commission

11. Anonymous Complaints

We encourage all complainants to provide their contact details, as this allows us to:

- Seek clarification or further information if needed
- Keep the complainant informed of progress
- Advise the complainant of the outcome

However, we will record anonymous complaints and investigate the facts available. In doing so, we will be mindful that anonymous complaints can sometimes be malicious. Individuals have a right to be protected from unsubstantiated and potentially malicious allegations.

Where an anonymous complaint is received:

- We will record the complaint
- We will investigate to the extent possible without being able to contact the complainant
- We will take proportionate action based on the evidence available
- We will not be able to provide the complainant with an outcome

12. Confidentiality and Data Protection

All complaints will be handled confidentially:

- Information will only be shared with those who need to know in order to investigate and respond
- Personal data will be processed in accordance with data protection legislation
- We may not be able to disclose information about actions taken against other individuals
- Records will be retained securely and in accordance with our retention schedule

In some circumstances, we may be required to share information with external bodies (such as the Charity Commission, police, or safeguarding authorities). We will explain this to the complainant if it applies.

13. Unreasonable or Vexatious Complaints

We are committed to handling all complaints fairly. However, in rare cases, complainant behaviour may become unreasonable. Examples include:

- Making repeated complaints about the same issue after the process has been exhausted
- Making excessive demands on time and resources
- Using abusive, offensive, or threatening language
- Making malicious or knowingly false allegations
- Harassing trustees or volunteers

If a complainant's behaviour becomes unreasonable, we may:

- Limit contact to specific times or methods
- Require communication in writing only
- Refuse to respond to further correspondence on a matter that has been concluded
- In extreme cases, terminate the complaint process

Any such decision will be made by the Board of Trustees and communicated to the complainant in writing with reasons.

14. Learning from Complaints

We view complaints as a valuable source of feedback. After each complaint is resolved, we will consider:

- What lessons can be learned
- Whether any changes should be made to policies, procedures, or training
- Whether similar issues could affect others
- Whether wider action is needed

The Board of Trustees will review a summary of complaints annually to identify patterns and systemic issues.

15. Statutory and Regulatory Reporting

Some complaints may require reporting to external bodies. The Board will consider whether to report to:

- The Charity Commission – if the matter constitutes a serious incident
- The Police – if criminal activity is suspected
- Safeguarding authorities – if there are concerns about children or adults at risk
- The Health and Safety Executive – if there are serious health and safety concerns
- The Information Commissioner's Office – if there has been a reportable data breach

Such reporting will be made regardless of the outcome of the complaint.

16. Roles and Responsibilities

16.1 Board of Trustees

- Approving and reviewing this policy
- Ensuring complaints are handled appropriately
- Making final decisions on appeals
- Considering statutory reporting requirements
- Reviewing complaint trends and learning
- Ensuring the policy is publicly available

16.2 Chair of Trustees

- Acting as the primary point of contact for formal complaints
- Overseeing the complaints process
- Allocating complaints for investigation
- Handling appeals (unless personally involved)
- Reporting serious matters to the Board

16.3 All Trustees and Volunteers

- Being familiar with this policy
- Treating complainants with courtesy and respect
- Recording and escalating complaints appropriately
- Cooperating with investigations
- Maintaining confidentiality

17. Record Keeping

We will maintain a Complaints Register recording:

- Date complaint received
- Nature of complaint
- Who investigated
- Outcome
- Any actions taken
- Whether the complainant was satisfied
- Any learning points identified

Complaint records will be retained for 6 years from the date of resolution, or longer if required for legal or insurance purposes.

18. Availability of This Policy

This policy is publicly available and will be:

- Published on the Charity's website
- Provided to anyone who requests it
- Given to anyone who indicates they wish to make a complaint
- Available in alternative formats on request

19. Review

This policy will be reviewed by the Board of Trustees every two years, or sooner if:

- There are significant changes to relevant legislation or regulatory guidance
- Complaints handling reveals significant gaps or issues
- The Charity receives feedback suggesting improvements are needed

20. Related Policies and Documents

This policy should be read in conjunction with:

- Safeguarding Policy
- Whistleblowing Policy
- Equality, Diversity and Inclusion Policy
- Data Protection Policy
- Trustee Code of Conduct
- Volunteer Management Policy

21. Approval and Version History

Version	Date	Approved By	Changes
1.0	*[Date]*	Board of Trustees	Initial policy

22. Trustee Declaration

We, the undersigned trustees of Gloucester Zakat Charity, confirm that we have read, understood, and approved this Complaints Policy and commit to its implementation.

Name	Role	Signature	Date
Mr Abdullah Abdul Samad Patel	Chair	A. Patel	01/02/2026
Mr Kamel Boulkenafet	Trustee	K. Boulkenafet	01/02/2026
Mr Hashim Moolla	Trustee	H. Moolla	01/02/2026
Mr Farouq Ginwalla	Trustee	F. Ginwalla	01/02/2026
Ms Mariam Qureshi	Trustee	M. Qureshi	01/02/2026

— End of Policy —